One Tennis Shoe

By Shel Silverstein

HARVEY: This is not going to be easy to say. It's not an easy subject to discuss –

SYLVIA: What is it? What? What? Are you sick? Are you --?

HARVEY: I'm fine –

SYLVIA: You're having an affair – you're in love with somebody else –

HARVEY: No, I'm fine – I love you –

SYLVIA: Well, then what?

HARVEY: I can't – say it – I've got to say it – I'm going to say it – you – are –becoming – a –

SYLVIA: Yes – yes – what? I'm becoming a what? I'm becoming a nag? I'm becoming a bore? What?

HARVEY: Worse.

SYLVIA: Nothing is worse than a bore. Harvey – what? What am I becoming?

HARVEY: You – are becoming a – you are turning into a – a – bag lady.

SYLVIA: A bag lady –

HARVEY: Yes. That's the hardest thing I'll ever have to say.

SYLVIA: I'm turning into a bag lady.

HARVEY: Yes, I'm afraid you are

INTRODUCTION

TOGETHER: *One Tennis Shoe by Shel Silverstein*

SYLVIA: I assume you mean one of those crazy old raggy ladies who pick things out of garbage cans and carry all their clothes in shopping bags and have lice in their hair and talk to themselves – I assume we're talking about the same ladies.

HARVEY: I didn't say you had lice in your hair.

SYLVIA: But you did say I was a bag lady.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

HARVEY: I said turning into – not was –

SYLVIA: Turning into a bag lady – well, that's pretty much like turning into a werewolf, isn't it?

HARVEY: Please – I'm just trying to –

SYLVIA: You are trying to tell me I'm a bag lady.

HARVEY: It's been evident for some time – you've been showing signs for quite some time.

SYLVIA: Signs –

HARVEY: Indications – symptoms – manifestations –

SYLVIA: Of becoming a bag lady –

HARVEY: Yes.

SYLVIA: There's no chance that you could be mistaken – you're sure. Well, I think I'd like a second opinion.

HARVEY: I'm serious about this.

SYLVIA: Harvey – look at me. Tell me – look at me, Harvey – wouldn't you say I was a little too young to be a bag lady? Maybe a little too old to be queen of the prom – but just a teensy weensy too young to be an old bag lady –

HARVEY: You think old bag ladies started out as old bag ladies? They started out as young women and then –

SYLVIA: And then they went to a wild party and somebody slipped them a shopping bag and it was all over.

HARVEY: I'm trying to make you understand –

SYLVIA: That I am a bag lady – because I am carrying a singular shopping bag – a Bloomingdale's shopping bag – that makes me – a bag lady – oh – Harvey – you are such a schmuck.

HARVEY: It's not because of carrying a shopping bag – it is because of what's in the bag –

SYLVIA: Well I'm sorry if the contents of my bag don't meet your standards – from now on I'll try to carry only Gucci shoes and Pierre Cardin –

HARVEY: I'm not talking about that – I'm telling you what ***not*** to carry.

SYLVIA: What ***not*** to carry – what should I not carry, Harvey? Tell me and I'll stop carrying it – tell me – tell me –

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

HARVEY: A sweater. And a plastic raincoat-

SYLVIA: A sweater and a raincoat make me a bag lady.

HARVEY: And a tennis shoe - shoe singular – one shoe. Why are you carrying one tennis shoe?

SYLVIA: I'm taking it down to the Bowery – to meet my wino lover – my one-legged wino lover – on Avenue B.

HARVEY: May I Inquire about the picture frame?

SYLVIA: It's a picture frame – beveled wood – probably pine – approximately nine by twelve with a wire –

HARVEY: Why the picture frame?

SYLVIA: Why indeed – how about to hang a picture with? How about that?

HARVEY: Why did you pick it up – out of the garbage can? That's what I –

SYLVIA: Not out of the garbage can – it was next to the can – leaning against the can – not touching the garbage.

HARVEY: Why did you pick it up from next to the can?

SYLVIA: Well, how can I hang a picture in it if I didn't pick it up?

HARVEY: Why didn't you buy a frame?

SYLVIA: Why buy a frame when this is a perfectly good frame?

HARVEY: That somebody threw away. And the couch cushion –

SYLVIA: It's a perfectly good cushion – I can use it on my desk chair.

HARVEY: So you just took it.

SYLVIA: When this cushion is covered in a blue floral patter it will be so –

HARVEY: And the magazines – all the magazines –

SYLVIA: Why are you attacking me like this? What's really bothering you?

HARVEY: This – this is what's really bothering me – what could bother a man more than seeing his wife collecting picture frames and tennis shoes and –

SYLVIA: Well don't forget the grapes while you're at it.

HARVEY: You have grapes in there?

SYLVIA: I have everything in here – I'm a bag lady, aren't I?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

HARVEY: You are a bag lady – you say you have grapes and a tennis shoe in there like it's perfectly normal – it is not normal – you are a bag lady.

SYLVIA: A moment ago I was ***becoming*** a bag lady – now I ***am*** a bag lady.

HARVEY: A moment ago I didn't know about the grapes.

SYLVIA: The grapes make me a bag lady.

HARVEY: The grapes and the raincoat and the tennis shoe –

SYLVIA: Stop harping on the tennis shoe – if the tennis shoe offends you I'll get rid of it – There – all right?

HARVEY: And the rest of the stuff –

SYLVIA: You want me to throw it all away? I will – I can just leave the bag here and walk away. . . Except for the picture frame – We can leave the rest right here –

HARVEY: Sylvia, do you not see what is happening to you?

SYLVIA: What is happening to me is you – you're attacking me –

HARVEY: I'm trying to reach you – I'm trying to make you see what you're doing.

SYLVIA: I'm not doing anything. I just found a nice little picture frame and you turn it into a –

HARVEY: We can stop this now – if we're aware of it we can nip it in the bud –

SYLVIA: I don't see what needs nipping – what? What am I doing?

HARVEY: Will you do me a favor? One favor.

SYLVIA: What is it?

HARVEY: Open your purse.

SYLVIA: Why?

HARVEY: As a favor to me – as a whim – Will you open your purse?

SYLVIA: You think there's another tennis shoe in my purse?

HARVEY: Will you - open your purse? Will you open your purse?

SYLVIA: No. A woman's bag – purse – is a personal thing –

HARVEY: I'm going to open this purse –

SYLVIA: You will not find another tennis shoe.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

HARVEY: *(Opens purse – looks away – then looks at her – he extends purse toward her)* Look – *(She looks away)* Look- *(She darts a glance)* Please look at this purse – *(She nervously looks)* What do you see? What? What do you see in your purse? *(Sylvia mumbles)* What? *(She mumbles again)* Speak out – let me hear you –

SYLVIA: Oatmeal – oatmeal! All right?

HARVEY: Oatmeal!

SYLVIA: Yes – are you happy now? Are you satisfied – oatmeal!

HARVEY: Cooked oatmeal.

SYLVIA: Yes – cooked oatmeal – cold cooked oatmeal – you are vicious – you knew there was oatmeal in that purse!

HARVEY: I want you to know it. I want you to see it.

SYLVIA: I see it – I see it.

HARVEY: Now – Why? – Why – is your purse filled – filled to the brim with old, cold, wet, cooked oatmeal. Why, Sylvia, why?

SYLVIA: I don't know.

HARVEY: Do you want a purse full of oatmeal?

SYLVIA: No –

HARVEY: Does any woman want a purse full of cooked oatmeal? Does anybody need that?

SYLVIA: No –

HARVEY: Then why is it there, Sylvia?

SYLVIA: I – don't know.

HARVEY: It's because you put it there, didn't you.

SYLVIA: I'm so embarrassed.

HARVEY: And you got it where?

SYLVIA: Please, you've made your point – I can't –

HARVEY: Where did you get the oatmeal? Did you cook it this morning at home? Did you cook it and then pour it in your purse?

SYLVIA: No.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

HARVEY: Then you found it – somewhere.

SYLVIA: Stouffers.

HARVEY: Stouffers – You went into Stouffers for breakfast and you – And you saw a bowl of oatmeal on the next table and reached –

SYLVIA: On the same table – on the table where I sat down - They hadn't cleared the table yet.

HARVEY: You sat down at a dirty table.

SYLVIA: It was crowded – they were busy.

HARVEY: And you emptied out the bowl into your purse.

SYLVIA: I didn't empty it – I put it in my purse – all of it.

HARVEY: The bowl too – Sylvia – What does this make you?

SYLVIA: The oatmeal?

HARVEY: The oatmeal and the hubcap and the ketchup bottle and the chicken bones – Chicken bones. Sylvia, you're an intelligent woman – what does this make you?

SYLVIA: A – bag – lady? I don't want to turn into a bag lady, Harvey – I don't want to push a supermarket cart down the street talking to myself and screaming at everybody – I don't want to sleep in a doorway.

HARVEY: You'll never sleep in a doorway –

SYLVIA: This is how it starts – the oatmeal – and shopping bags – then talking to myself, then screaming at people on the street and rummaging through garbage cans and begging for money and not bathing and weaving things into my hair and growing a moustache and drinking wine and sleeping in doorways and getting arrested – Oh my God, Harvey, don't let them arrest me – don't let me sleep in the doorway, please, Harvey – please –

HARVEY: Don't get hysterical –

SYLVIA: And if I start weaving that crazy stuff into my hair you've got to stop me – slap me –

HARVEY: I could never slap –

SYLVIA: You've got to be forceful, Harvey. They have no homes – they prowl the streets – they don't get their hair done – they don't have to bathe – they don't have to shave their legs – they don't worry about it – No cooking to do – no house to clean – no man to – consider.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

They scream out "Hey buster, watch your fender – you son-of-a-bitch – Watch out, you rotten creep – pompous self-righteous – Kiss – me." *(Slap)* Ow! Thank you, Harvey – I'm leaving that bag right there – we can go home. I'm all right now!

HARVEY: I jut wanted you to be aware of –

SYLVIA: I'm grateful – you saved me, I'm lucky to have you, Harvey. I'm going to take this sandwich home for later –

HARVEY: Sylvia. . .

SYLVIA: That's all right – I don't need it. Wait a minute – what if they see we're leaving the bag – what if the waitress sees – and shouts – "Hey lady, you're forgetting your bag" – I'd die of embarrassment, Harvey, I'll tell you what – I'll take it outside and we can dump it in the nearest trash basket – now, I know there's a large basket over on Third Avenue and Fifty-Seventh – oh, wait – there's a better one on Fifty-Ninth Street – we can just -

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Shel Silverstein
Book: An Adult Evening of Shel Silverstein
ISBN: 978-0822218739
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): March 2003

AWARD HISTORY

IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY